cold war because it shared values with both blocs. With the Western countries India shared ideals like democracy, individual liberty, human rights, rule of law, secularism and pluralism as well as the need for a scientific temper. At the same time, India appreciated the anti-colonialism and Asia-centrism of the Soviet Union even as it was 'repelled by the Soviet submerging of the individual in the name of the State'. [21]

India's preference for the middle path had emerged even before independence from Britain. In his first official pronouncement on foreign policy on 7 September 1946, Nehru, as interim prime minister and external affairs minister, stated: 'We propose as far as possible to keep away from the power politics of groups aligned against one another. … We send our greetings to the people of the US, to whom destiny has given a major role in international affairs … To that other great nation of the world, the Soviet Union, which also carries a vast responsibility for shaping world events, we send greetings.'[22] This, in effect, was a succinct statement of non-alignment even before that term had been coined.

In a recent book, Priya Chacko furthers the argument that moral influences lay at the core of India's post-Independence foreign policy. According to Chacko, for Nehru foreign policy was a tool to help construct India's identity as a post-colonial state. However, there was an underlying contradiction at the core of this policy: modernity was perceived both as responsible for India's past colonization as well as the cure for India's backwardness. Chacko maintains that this ambivalence is the reason for the strong moral dimension of Indian foreign policy. The only way out of this ambivalence was by asserting India's 'civilizational exceptionalism – the idea that India is equipped with unique moral qualities'. India as a 'moral power' would change the existing global norms and ways of conducting international relations and move the world from violence towards peace.[23]

The idea that India could lead the world, albeit in a different way than traditional global or regional hegemons, has periodically surfaced in Indian